

RUNESTONE

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**For those of consequence a mound should be raised to
their memory, and for all other warriors who had been
distinguished for bravery a standing stone**

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

When developing this game I have drawn inspiration and shamelessly stolen ideas from many existing works of the RPG scene, foremost among them:

Mythras by Pete Nash and Lawrence Whitaker

Knave by Ben Milton

The One Ring 2E by Francesco Nepitello and Free League

Mothership by Sean McCoy and Tuesday Knight Games

One work of fiction has been central inspiration for the game: The comic series Thorgal by Van Hamme and Rosiński, especially Thorgal: The Archers.

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INTRODUCTION

This is an early alpha. Feedback can be given on the tesolberg.itch.io/runestone page, or on the Discord server.

WHAT IS THIS AND WHY DID I MAKE IT?

I wanted to play sword and sorcery adventures with a game system rigged for:

- Highly skilled adventurers from the get go.
- Progression through the impact of the characters' action on the game world, not through "number go up" on a character sheet.
- Easy to read die rolls with minimal arithmetic. You roll a hand of d6s and every 4-6 is a hit. One hit is usually enough to succeed.
- Dynamic, fast and dangerous combat where predicting your opponent's next action is key to succeeding.
- Not a meat grinder. When things go south, you are more likely to get knocked out than die. Then you are probably sold as a slave, and your perilous path continues from there.
- Competency should be cut into the right number of slices—not too many (e.g. 50 skills), and not too few (e.g. 3 attributes).
- I wanted difference in skill to strongly impact how well characters do on difficult tasks. When you play a legendary archer, you should be able to land shots that are near impossible for other characters.
- No duplicate or near duplicate values: No concurrent DEX attribute, DEX save and acrobatics skill.
- No special abilities. Solutions to problems are not found in special abilities listed on your character sheet, but through interactions with the fictional world, treating it like a real place.
- Light scaffolding for wilderness travel, including encumbrance and slot inventory.

This is what I came up with. The game is still under development. If you have ideas or feedback that can improve the game, I would love to hear from you.

PLAYING THE GAME

GAME PROCEDURES

Runestone has four main procedures, covering the most important aspects of play:

- **Basic scene procedure.** The game's main loop. Used for most scenes that are not covered by one of the three more specialized procedures below.
- **Combat.** See p. xx.
- **Travel.** See p. xx.
- **Site exploration.** Used for exploring dangerous areas like tombs, ruins, hostile fortresses etc. See p. xx.

The basic scene procedure is usually implicitly engaged when the gamemaster (GM) describes a new scene. A shift to combat, travel or site exploration is stated explicitly by the GM.

SCENES

A **scene** is any situation that will be played out in detail in order to resolve an interesting choice or interaction. Situations or events without an interesting choice or interaction are not considered scenes, and are described in broad strokes by the GM (or players) when needed. A scene is over when the interesting choice or interaction has been resolved.

When one scene ends, the GM moves the game to the beginning of the next scene (i.e. the next interesting situation), stitching the two scenes together with broad stroked-description when necessary.

THE BASIC SCENE PROCEDURE

This game's main procedure has 4 steps:

1. **Describe the scene.** The GM describes the scene from the player characters' (PCs) point of view.
2. **Clarification:** The players can ask clarifying questions about the scene, and the GM answers questions based on what the characters can reasonably observe from their current vantage point. If a player's requested information require specific actions to uncover, the GM explains the action needed to answer the question.
3. **Describe actions.** The players describe what they do.
4. **Resolve actions.**
 1. **Actions that are not risky** just happen as the players describe them.

2. **Risky actions** are resolved with a check.

5. **Impact.** The GM describes the impact the players' actions have on their environment, and the procedure either returns to step 3 or the GM transitions the game to a new scene.

Resolving actions

Most actions should be resolved by simply finding a plausible outcome, given the proposed action and how the fictional game world is supposed to work.

The players will often do this on their own, with no need for the GM to provide a second description of their action. If, on the other hand, the action seems like it simply will not work, the GM tells the player. If the action is risky (something valuable is at stake), the GM asks for a check.

What is at stake can be anything related to the players' goals or their means to achieve their goals, including, but not limited to:

- Opportunities
- A relationship to an NPC
- Items that is not easily replaced
- A favorable position
- Useful information
- Money
- Their health
- Available inventory slots
- Time

The watermark of a risky action is that both succeeding and failing significantly alter the world state. If failing does not alter the world state (i.e. the situation is in all significant aspects the same as it was before the action), the action is not risky.

Risky actions are resolved with a check. If unsure about the viability or risk of a plan, it is usually helpful to clarify two aspects:

1. **Intent.** What is the goal?
2. **Plan.** How is the player accomplishing it?

Zooming the basic scene procedure in and out

The basic scene procedure is zoomed in or out to match the scale of the scene's focus, i.e. the scale of the interesting choice(s) and interactions.

Zoomed-out example: The company enters a previously visited settlement. The players already have a list or map of all overt NPCs and points of interest. The GM describes the company approaching the settlement, and any overt changes since their last visit. One iteration of the basic scene procedure is used to resolve the PCs' actions for the rest of the day, where each PC gets to perform one major action (like visiting an NPC, shop for

gear or pay their respects at the local temple).

Zoomed-in example: The GM describes the company arriving at the manor of an allied minor noble, only to find the grounds eerily quiet, and the main door to the manor visibly forced open. The players narrates how they quietly enter the building, and the GM describes how they arrive in the main hall, and that they suddenly hear a creak from a floorboard in the next room. The GM asks the players what they do. After some frantic hand-signaling, one player states she moves to the door where the sound emanated from, while the other players indicate they stay put and keep quiet to not give away their presence. The GM describes the PC now standing by the door hearing a soft shuffling sound on the other side, like someone turning over pages in a book.

CHECKS

The core resolution mechanic is called a check. To resolve a check:

1. **Clarify goal.** The player defines what happens if the check succeeds.
2. **Clarify risk.** The GM defines what happens if the check fails, and sets a difficulty class (DC) of 1 (default), 2 (hard) or 3 (very hard), representing how hard it is to avoid the risk.
3. **Choose skill.** The GM decides which skill applies to the action. If more than one skill could reasonably apply, the player chooses which of those skills to use.
4. **Roll dice.** The player rolls a number of d6s equal to their skill level. Every 4+ counts as a hit. Every 6 explodes and the player rolls an additional d6. If the player scores a number of hits equal to or greater than the DC, they achieve their goal and avoid the risk. If they score less hits than the DC the risk materializes.
5. **Description.** The player describes the outcome based on step 1 and 2. If the outcome reveals new information about the world, the GM provides it.

Supreme outcomes

Rolling one or more hits above the DC indicates a supreme outcome. When you get a supreme outcome, choose one additional effect from the list below and incorporate it into step 5 above.

- ▶ **Speed.** The action is completed in significantly shorter time than normal.
- ▶ **Stealth.** The action is performed without drawing unwanted attention.
- ▶ **Supreme quality.** The result of the action is of supreme quality.
- ▶ **Additional information.** Additional useful information is gained.
- ▶ **Extended reach.** The action affects more than just the intended target.
- ▶ **Greater progress.** The action leads to greater progress than expected.
- ▶ **Help an ally.** The action compensates for an ally that is struggling. This is incorporated

into group checks where more than one member of the company rolls. A player choosing this effect can compensate for an ally failing their roll.

Opposed checks

When one character goes up against another in a contest, each roll a number of d6s equal to their relevant skill level, and the one rolling the most hits wins. Rolling the same number of hits signifies an unchanged situation.

Advantage and disadvantage

When you have a significant advantage (ADV) or disadvantage (DIS) in the fictional situation, add or remove 1d6 before you roll, respectively. In cases where both ADV and DIS applies, they cancel each other out, regardless of how many there are of each. If DIS nets you 0d6, roll 2d6 and keep the lowest.

ASSISTING ANOTHER CHARACTER

When one player is attempting something requiring a check, another player can assist if they can describe a reasonable way to do so. The character receiving help gains ADV on their check.

GROUP CHECKS

When multiple characters collaborate on a prolonged task, a group check is employed.

- ▶ When the **strongest performance in the group** is the deciding factor (like following tracks in the wilderness), the most skilled character rolls the check.
- ▶ Other times, the **sum of the group's effort** is what's important (like building a raft and getting to the other side of a rapidly flowing river). The GM sets the Opposition, and all participants roll one check each. To succeed on the overall task, they must all succeed on their checks, but a critical success cancels another participant's failure, and a critical failure cancels another participant's success.
- ▶ When the **weakest performance in the group** is the deciding factor (like a company of PCs attempting to pass unseen over a palisade), the least skilled participant rolls the check.

USING CHECKS

The difficulty of a check should default to DC1. The players have each chosen the skills they want to excel at, and challenge should come from the overall precariousness of the situation, not from a high chance of failing within their specialty. The exemption from this is when players attempt actions within their specialty that would be neigh impossible for the average individual. The difficulty of the check should then be adjusted to requiring 2 or even 3 hits.

Tension during a check should come from knowing exactly what will happen if you fail or pass the roll, but not yet knowing which of the two will come to pass.

Die Probabilities							
DC/dice	0d	1d	2d	3d	4d	5d	6d
1	.25	.50	.75	.88	.94	.97	.98
2	.00	.00	.25	.50	.69	.81	.89
3	.00	.00	.00	.12	.31	.50	.66

Skill Levels	
Skill Level	Description
1	Average
2	Adept
3	Veteran
4	Master

Dice	1+ hits	2+ hits	3+ hits	4+ hits
1	.50	.08	.01	.00
2	.75	.33	.09	.02
3	.88	.56	.25	.08
4	.94	.73	.43	.20
5	.97	.84	.60	.34
6	.98	.91	.73	.49

PLAYER CHARACTERS

To create a character, go through the following steps:

1. **Backgrounds.** Roll 2 backgrounds from the Backgrounds table on the opposite page. These backgrounds represent what your character has engaged in before adventure arrived in their lives. Add each background at level 1 to your character sheet.
2. **Skills.** Choose one skill at level 4, two skills at level 3, three skills at level 2. The remaining skills are at level 1.
3. **Gear.** Write down your items on your characters sheet. Your character starts with one ration, a waterskin and a bedroll, each taking up 1 inventory slot. You also get 15 silver pieces in a pouch (the first 100 coins you carry counts as a tiny item and does not take up a slot). Roll once on the Starting Shield and Armor table, and once on the gear table. Choose one weapon and a dagger (see p.xx) to finalize your starting equipment.
4. **Hit points (HP).** Note your maximum hit points (8 + grit) on your character sheet.
5. **Name your character.**

SKILLS

The skills of Runestone are selected so that each skill embodies a sword and sorcery-archetype.

Your skills are the combined result of natural ability and relevant experience, and a skill's level determine how well you perform difficult and risky actions falling within the given skill's domain. The different skill levels, ranging from 1 (average) to 4 (mastery), together with their description and cost, are given in the Skill Levels table. The cost is the number of marks needed to advance the skill from the skill level below (see Character Progression).

Skills are divided into the 4 categories of core, advanced, combat and backgrounds.

Core skills

- **Brawn.** Used for melee combat, thrown weapons, feats of raw strength and influences how much gear you can carry before being encumbered.
- **Grace.** Reflexes, balance, fine and gross motor skill. Shooting arrows with a bow. Dodging missile attacks. Moving without being seen or heard.
- **Grit.** Willpower, physical toughness and endurance. Higher grit gives your character more hit points and increases the amount of gear you can carry before being encumbered.

Specialty skills

- **Apothecary.** Knowledge of herbs and fungi. Care for the sick or injured. Giving first aid to allies that are downed in a fight (and possibly saving their lives).
- **Sorcery.**
- **Survival.** Tracking, hunting, fishing, building fires, making shelters, jury-rigging tools, navigating in the wilderness.
- **Thievery.** Opening locks, breaking-and-entering, picking pockets, planting or swapping items on another person, disarming or setting traps, forgery, using disguises.

Backgrounds

Your character's backgrounds describe what he or she has done before answering the call to adventure. Each of your backgrounds are at level 2 unless you increased it during character creation.

Custom skills

Several blank skill entries have been included on the character sheet to accommodate custom skills.

CHARACTER PROGRESSION

When you fail a check, and the skill's "F" box is unchecked, check the "F" box and add one mark on the skill's accumulator field.

If the number of marks in the skill's accumulator field matches the cost of advancing the skill to it's next level (the number in the "NL" field), advance the skill immediately, erase all marks in the skill's accumulator field, and update the cost of advancing the skill to it's next level.

All checked F-boxes are cleared at the end of each session.

Should a PC reach level 6 (indicating legendary capabilities), but wants to continue advancing the skill in further sessions, the cost of advancing to new levels follows the same pattern as before, i.e. 16 marks for level 7, 18 marks for level 8 etc.

INVENTORY

Carried items occupy inventory slots based roughly on weight and bulk:

- **Regular.** Occupies 1 slot. Examples: One-handed weapons, bundled items (like 3 torches or 20 arrows), items that can be carried in one hand.
- **Heavy.** Occupies 2 slots. Examples: Two-

Starting Shield and Armor

d6	
1	None
2	Light armor (1 slot, 1 armor point)
3-4	Light armor and shield
5	Medium armor (3 slots, 2 armor points)
6	Medium armor and shield

Gear

d20	Item	Description
1	Tinderbox	Roll survival vs. opposition o. Fumble: Moisture gets in, cannot be used for 1 day. Fail: 30 minutes to light flame. Success: 10 minutes. Critical: 1 minute.
2	Rope (20 m)	
3	Iron Spikes (10)	
4	Small Mirror	
5	Chalk (5 Pieces)	Tiny.
6	Crowbar	
7	Toolbox	Contains a small hammer, 20 nails, pliers
8	Small Bell	Tiny.
9	Grappling Hook	
10	Bear trap	
11	Lantern	
12	Bag of Marbles	
13	Empty Glass Bottles (3)	
14	Needle and Thread	Tiny.
15	Canvas Sheet (2x2 m)	
16	Tin Whistle	Tiny.
17	Small Hand Drill	
18	Fishing Tackle	
19	Spyglass	
20	Cooking Kit	A small pot, frying pan and utensils.

Skill Levels

Level	Description	Cost in marks
0	Untrained	-
1	Beginner	4
2	Adept	6
3	Veteran	8
4	Master	10
5	Grand Master	12
6	Legend	14

Backgrounds

d100		d100	
1	Acrobat	51	Innkeeper
2	Actor	52	Jailer
3	Alchemist	53	Jester
4	Apothecary	54	Jeweler
5	Apprentice Magician	55	Lawman
6	Architect	56	Leatherworker
7	Armorer	57	Logger
8	Assassin	58	Locksmith
9	Astronomer	59	Mason
10	Baker	60	Mercenary
11	Bandit	61	Merchant
12	Barber	62	Miller
13	Bard	63	Miner
14	Beekeeper	64	Monk
15	Beggar	65	Musician
16	Blacksmith	66	Noble
17	Boatman	67	Nomad
18	Bookbinder	68	Outlaw
19	Burglar	69	Painter
20	Butcher	70	Performer
21	Bounty Hunter	71	Physician
22	Bowyer	72	Pirate
23	Brewer	73	Poet
24	Candle-maker	74	Politician
25	Carpenter	75	Potter
26	Cartwright	76	Priest(ess)
27	Charlatan	77	Prisoner
28	Cheese-maker	78	Puppeteer
29	Chef	79	Rat Catcher
30	Cobbler	80	Sailor
31	Conman/-woman	81	Scholar
32	Cooper	82	Scribe
33	Ditch Digger	83	Sculptor
34	Dyer	84	Seer
35	Exile	85	Servant
36	Falconer	86	Shepard
37	Farmer	87	Shipwright
38	Fisherman	88	Singer
39	Fletcher	89	Slave
40	Gardener	90	Soldier
41	Gladiator	91	Smuggler
42	Glassblower	92	Squire
43	Goldsmith	93	Stablehand
44	Gravedigger	94	Street Urchin
45	Guard	95	Tailor
46	Haberdasher	96	Tanner
47	Hat Maker	97	Tax Collector
48	Hermit	98	Temptress/Seducer
49	Horse Trainer	99	Vagabond
50	Hunter	00	Weaver

Armor

Type	Example	Damage reduction	Skill Penalty	Slots	Price
Light	Leather	1	-	2	25
Medium	Chain	2	-1 to grace	3	75
Heavy	Plate	3	-2 to grace	4	300

handed weapons, shields, bows.

- **Tiny.** Does not occupy slots. An item is tiny if it can be hidden in a closed fist. Examples: A coin, ring or key.
- **Coins and gems.** 100 coins or gems take up 1 slot. The first 100 coins a character carries counts as a tiny item.
- **Worn clothing** does not take up any slots.

Equipped items

Retrieving an equipped item can be done for free once on your turn during combat. Items like shields, weapons and armor must be in equipped slots to be used.

Stowed items

Retrieving a stowed item during combat (or your second retrieval of an equipped item that turn) costs an action.

CARRYING CAPACITY AND ENCUMBRANCE

All characters can use all 10 equipment slots, 2 stowed slots and 5 encumbrance slots (marked with ENC on the character sheet).

If any of your encumbrance slots are in use (holding an item or marked with fatigue), your move slowly (anyone with normal movement speed will be able to catch up with you) and you get -2 travel points during a day of travel.

Characters unlock a number of additional stowed item slots equal to the sum of their brawn and grit level.

Fatigue

When you gain an instance of fatigue, mark the *f*-box of an empty inventory slot. Marking the *f*-box of a non-empty slot causes any item contained in that slot to be dropped immediately.

When an inventory slot is marked with fatigue it counts towards encumbrance just like an item occupying the same slot would do.

You can gain several instances of fatigue, each taking up one slot, signifying a more serious fatigue state.

Clearing fatigue

Spending a whole day and night resting in a settlement or safe haven clears 2 instances of fatigue. This requires that the character does little more than sipping beverage and keeping their legs up for the

whole waking part of the day.

GAME WORLD KNOWLEDGE

Characters' game world knowledge is handled with a few simple principles:

- All characters know all common knowledge in the (sub)culture(s) they belong to.
- In addition, they have broad knowledge relating to their backgrounds and skills.
- All other knowledge must be discovered in-game.

SOCIAL INTERACTION

Social interactions are conducted by either

- Speaking in character and acting out the interaction, or
- Describing the social strategy taken by the character(s).

The GM uses the NPC's goals and demeanor to find a reasonable reaction. When it is uncertain how an NPC would react, the GM rolls a 1d6 reaction roll. Apply ADV/DIS (by rolling 2d6 and keeping the highest/lowest) as suited. Only roll when it is reasonable that the NPC's reaction could go both ways.

- 6: Yes.
- 4-5: Yes, but...
- 2-3: No, but...
- 1: No.

Social information

The GM is the eyes and ears of the PCs. Clues about what NPCs feel and think should be considered overt information, and thus provided to the players, unless the NPC in question is actively attempting to hide his or her inner state to the PCs.

COMBAT

Combat is not meant to be played out on a grid. Even so, tokens and a wet-erase mat or similar are sometimes useful to represent zones and their relative position, barriers and other important parts of the environment.

Notice that the rules for 1-on-1 combat is symmetrical, favoring neither attacker nor defender. This means that many combat situations can be played out without going into strict turn order, but instead describing actions more freely, resolving bouts as they happen.

INITIATION OF TURN ORDER

1. The Skirmish rules are engaged when the GM declares that the game enters turn order.
2. Combatants are placed in zones. The players choose their starting zone as long as it is reasonable in the fiction.
3. The players roll a d6. On a 4+, the players get their Turn to act first, followed by their opponents. On a 1-3, the opponents take their Turn first, followed by the players.

At the start of combat, the Turn starts at the player seated to the GM's left, then continues in a clockwise manner around the table. Players can freely pass and delay their Turn until later, but must take (or forfeit) their Turn before it passes over to the GM.

When the Turn passes to the GM, the NPCs all get their Turn to act in the order decided by the GM.

Combat round sequence:

1. Ranged attacks if not moving (clashes from last round counts)
2. Movement
3. Establish clashes
4. Ranged attacks at -1d for combatants that moved
5. Clashes are resolved
6. Other actions (including extra movement)

ACTIONS IN COMBAT

Any action that can be performed within approximately 10 seconds can be attempted during a Turn. Actions are resolved with the standard rules for action resolution, but some common actions are given extra specifications:

- **Attack.** See Melee attacks and Ranged attacks below.
- **Regain footing.**
- **Pick up an item.**

- **Aim.** On your next turn, you gain ADV on a ranged attack, as long as you do nothing but aim in the meantime.
- **Ready action.** You define an if -> then condition, e.g. "If the highwayman pops out from cover, then I fire an arrow at him". Your action triggers when the condition is fulfilled. You cannot change your condition after the Turn passes to the GM, but you can abstain from going through with your readied action when the condition is met.
- **Sprint.** Move an additional zone.
- **Flee from combat.** Requires a viable path off the battlefield from your current zone. You can pick up one adjacent downed ally and carry them off the battlefield as part of fleeing from combat.

A combatant that has already been attacked this Turn cannot be attacked in melee again if there are opponents in the same zone that has not been attacked this Turn. Opponent's that are prone or otherwise unable or unwilling to fight effectively, does not count in this regard.

Example: Two PCs go up against two bandits, all occupying the same zone. The first PC attacks one of the bandits. The second PC cannot attack the same bandit, as that would violate the rule above.

Up to 5 human-sized combatants can engage 1 human-sized foe in melee at the same time.

MELEE ATTACKS

When a PC attacks or is attacked by an NPC, the player rolls a melee check against the opponent's combat DC and counts up the hits:

- **Below the DC:** The NPC inflicts 1 x weapon damage for each hit short of the DC. The GM describes the NPC's attack, while the player describes the effect it has on the PC.
- **Equal or above the DC:** The PC inflicts 1 x weapon damage to the opponent for matching the DC, and 1 x weapon damage for each hit exceeding the DC. The player describes the PC's attack, while the GM describes the effect it has on the NPC.

Weapon damage

The weapon damage of melee weapons and thrown weapons is the weapon's base damage + brawn.

The weapon damage of bows is the weapon's base damage + grace.

Dodging

The target can declare that they dodge instead of parrying. If they do, they use grace instead of melee during the check, but cannot gain any gambits.

Example 1: Resolution of a PC attacking a bandit.

Player: I attack the bandit!

GM: That will be a DC 1.

Player rolls 3d6, matching their melee skill level

Player: 2 hits! I give him a cut with my sword for 2 damage and sweep him off his feet!

GM: The bandit lands on the ground with a groan.

Example 2: A PC with melee 2 faces off against a Level 0 goblin and a Level 1 hobgoblin, and it is the GM's turn. The GM decides the goblin attacks first, and rolls 3 (5 under the player's melee defense TN of 8, resulting in a botch), giving the PC a gambit against the goblin. The player selects damage, slaying the goblin. Next the hobgoblin attacks, this time with ADV (since this is the PC's second Reaction this Turn), and the GM rolls 4 and 9, keeping the 9 and adding 1 for the hobgoblin's level. A total for 10 equals a hit, giving the GM a gambit against the player. She selects trip as the hobgoblin's gambit, putting the player at a dangerous disadvantage.

Gambits

Any time you inflict weapon damage, you can choose to exchange 1 x weapon damage for one gambit. You can select several gambits during one attack.

- ▶ **Trip opponent.** The opponent falls prone. A standing combatant are at an ADV against a prone opponent in melee. A character trying to hit a prone character with a ranged weapon is at a DIS.
- ▶ **Push, pull or throw.** The effect is dependent on the immediate environment. Ideally, consult with your GM about your intent for this effect before rolling the check. Pushing an opponent into an obstacle causes them to fall prone.
- ▶ **Pass.** Move past an opponent that tries to prevent it. Optionally enter an adjacent zone.
- ▶ **Sunder armor.** -1 wound TN until armor is repaired (at a ratio of the armor's cost).
- ▶ **Disarm.** The opponent drops their weapon (or shield).
- ▶ **Recover a dropped item.** The item must be in the same zone.
- ▶ **Regain footing.** You get up from prone position.
- ▶ **Establish or remove an advantage or disadvantage.** Describe in the fiction what is happening, e.g. you throw sand in your opponent's eyes or loosen their belt. If you use minis, put a red marker for a disadvantage or a blue marker for advantage next to the mini.
- ▶ **Force surrender.** The opponent must already be in a disadvantageous position and you must inflict enough wounds to take him or

her out. Instead of incapacitating the victim, he or she is placed in a position where they are unable to prevent the opponent from threatening an incapacitating blow (e.g. blade at throat).

Custom gambits

Players can suggest any reasonable gambit they can think of. To evaluate a player-suggested gambit:

1. **Clarify intent.** The player states what they want to do and how they want to achieve it.
2. **The GM evaluates the suggestion.** Especially ambitious gambits may require certain conditions.

Going directly for a gambit

If your brawn or grace are significantly stronger than your melee skill, you might want to directly attempt an effect that can reasonably be covered by the skill, e.g. throwing an enemy off a cliff using brawn. To resolve such actions, roll a check with the appropriate skill against the DC of the opponent. If you meet the DC, you succeed. If you exceed the DC, the effect might be stronger than expected.

Grappling and unarmed attacks

When you fight unarmed (both when grappling and otherwise) you can roll your check with either melee, brawn or grace, representing different fighting styles.

Two special grapple gambits exists:

- ▶ **Grapple (unarmed).** The victim is grappled.
- ▶ **Slip free.** Ends a grapple.

You grapple another combatant by successfully attacking or defending unarmed, and choosing the grapple gambit.

A grappled character cannot perform other actions than fight against their grappler and any other attackers. They cannot move to an adjacent zone except as a gambit.

Escaping a grapple requires winning a slip free gambit. The grapple also ends if the grappler performs any other action than attacking their grappled victim.

Attacking, or defending, unarmed against an armed opponent is done at DIS.

A weapon wielded by a grappled character functions as an unarmed attack (-1 damage) unless it is a dagger or gladius, which does normal damage (+0). The grappler cannot draw or wield any weapon without ending the grapple.

A grappled character is at DIS to the grappler and any other attackers. If the grappled character is armed with a dagger or gladius, this DIS is cancelled out against the grappler but not against other attackers.

Protecting allies

One combatant can protect one ally from one opponent, effectively hindering an opponent from

getting adjacent to their ally. Three combatants can protect one ally from an unlimited number of opponents.

Impalement

When you cause a wound with a piercing weapon, you can choose to leave the weapon impaled in your opponent. The opponent performs all checks at DIS until the weapon is removed. Removing the weapon causes an automatic wound.

RANGED ATTACKS

Ranged attacks are resolved like melee attacks, but attackers use the ranged skill, and the attack can only be dodged (the target must use grace and cannot gain any gambits).

Ranged attacks have their own list of gambits:

- **Damage.** You inflict your weapon's damage to your opponent.
- **Disarming shot.** Knock an opponent's weapon out of their hand.
- **Pinning shot.** Pins an opponent's clothing, equipment or limb to a surface, preventing their movement until they spend an action to free themselves.
- **Ricochet shot.** Bounce an arrow off a wall, shield or other hard surface to strike a target behind cover. Must be combined with another gambit to have an effect against the target.
- **Attack again.** Immediately perform another attack at -1 support.
- **Over-penetration.** The missile goes through your target and inflicts weapon damage to an opponent directly behind the target. Must be combined with the damage gambit.

Ranged attacks gets DIS **when the target is far away, prone, in partial cover or wielding a shield.** What is considered far away must be adjudicated by the GM. 20 meters or more than 2 zones is the suggested guideline when using a bow.

If a ranged attack misses, one randomly selected combatant in the same zone to the target (if there is any) takes weapon damage from the missile.

Aiming

If you spend an action aiming, you gain +1 to your next ranged attack, as long as you are not attacked and do nothing but aim in the meantime.

ZONES AND MOVEMENT

During combat, distances are abstracted into zones. All combatants in one zone can interact with each other (e.g. perform ranged and melee attacks, oppose actions etc).

When visualizing zones, do not draw realistic maps. Instead, draw boxes with an identifying feature in them (a box with a table and chair for the common room of the tavern and a box with "Bar" written on

it for the bar area). Draw the boxes so that connected zones are in contact with each other.

WEAPONS

HEALTH AND DYING

A creature's health is represented by hit points (HP) and conditions.

Hit Points

Player characters' **maximum HP** (max HP) is equal to 8 + grit. When you take damage, check an equal number of "damage-taken" boxes on your character sheet. Loss of HP reflects cuts and bruises.

When you have taken damage at least equal to your max HP you are knocked out, roll a fate roll without looking at the result (preferably roll under a dice cup). If you have 0 conditions from before, roll 2d6 and keep the highest. If you have 1 condition from before, roll 1d6. If you have 2 or more conditions from before, roll 2d6 and keep the lowest.

The first time someone uses an action to check on you, that person looks at the die you rolled, and they discover your true state:

On a 6, they find you merely scratched up and you wake up.

On a 4-5, they find you roughed up, you gain a condition and you wake up in 1d6 minutes.

On a 3, they find you in a severe state, dying in 6 hours unless prevented by a successful hard apothecary check. Only one PCs can attempt one apothecary check. In addition, one NPC can attempt one apothecary check. If successfully treated, you gain a condition and wake up in 1d6 x 10 minutes.

On a 2 they find you in a severe state, dying in 1 hour unless prevented by a successful very hard apothecary check. Only one PCs can attempt one apothecary check. In addition, one NPC can attempt one apothecary check. If successfully treated, you gain a condition and wake up in 1d6 hours.

On a 1, you are already dead.

Healing HP

When you take a couple of minutes to catch your breath and take a swing of the mead skin, you regain all your HP.

Conditions

When you gain a condition, you decide the nature of that which has befallen your character. You must also specify which core skill is affected by the condition, giving all checks with that core skill -1d. Then roll 1d6 to decide the duration die of the condition:

6: d4

4-5: d6

3: d8
2: d10
1: d12

NPCs

It is assumed that NPCs die instantly at 0 HP.

If a player sneaks up on an NPC and wants to take them alive, they must gain the force surrender gambit. A player that has successfully moved up behind an unaware NPC can, if attacking unarmed, establish a grapple free of cost before rolling to attack with ADV. Preventing the victim from screaming for help is a gambit. Chocking them out functions as a coup de gr s.

To knock an NPC unconscious the PC must reduce the HP of the NPC to 0 HP with a blunt weapon hit. There is a 3-in-6 chance that the blow killed the NPC instead of knocking them unconscious.

Many NPCs have Traits. NPCs gets +1 when a Trait indicates that they are especially capable at the task at hand. They get -1 when a Trait suggests the opposite.

ARMOR

Armor reduces damage from an attack.

Heavy armor impedes performance on actions covered by stealth and grace (see Armor table below).

ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES

If one opponent has a clear advantage over the other in the fictional situation, this should incur ADV/DIS on relevant checks, including attacks. Examples include:

Weapons			
Type	Damage	Slots	Price
Unarmed	0	-	-
Improvised weapon	1	Varies	-
Dagger	2	1	5
1-handed weapon	3	1	15
2-handed weapon	4	2	20

- Attacking from higher ground: +1d
- Hindered by deep snow, mud or water: -1d
- Fighting prone: -1d
- Performing a ranged attack against a prone target: -1d.

The rules describe several situations that would, in most cases, imply an advantage or disadvantage. Regardless, the fictional situation should always be given precedence when deciding on whether an advantage exists or not. It is the GM's job to be the final arbiter in these matters.

INVENTORY INTERACTION

- **Interacting with an item** (e.g. reading from a document, throwing an item, operating a winch) is an action.
- **Dropping an item** during your turn is a free action. Recovering a dropped item is an action.
- **Retrieving or stashing an equipped item** (like sheathing or drawing a weapon) is a free action once on your turn. Doing so again during the same turn is an action.
- **Retrieving or stashing a stowed item** is an action.

MOUNTED COMBAT

Fate table	
1d6	State
6	Merely scratched up. It looked worse than it was. You wake up.
4-5	Roughed up. You gain a condition. Wake up in 1d6 minutes.
3	Badly wounded. Dying in 6 hours unless prevented by a successful hard apothecary check. Only one PCs can attempt one apothecary check. In addition, one NPC can attempt one apothecary check. If successful, gain a condition and wake up in 1d6 x 10 minutes.
2	As above, but dying in 1 hour unless prevented by a very hard apothecary check. If successful, you gain a condition and wake up in 1d6 hours.
1	You are already dead.

Armor					
Type	Example	Damage reduction	Skill Penalty	Slots	Price
Light	Leather	1	-	2	25
Medium	Chain	2	-1 to grace and stealth	3	75
Heavy	Plate	3	-2 to grace and stealth	4	300

When attacking or defending on horseback against opponents on foot, roll melee +1. When you attack and you spent your last turn charging your opponent, you gain +2 instead of +1.

EXAMPLE NPCS

Bandit rabble

Level 1, HP 1

Typical gear: 1-h sword (3 dmg), dagger (2 dmg, can be thrown), leather armor, d12 (6) sp

Usual wants: Money. Wine. Valuable gear. Easy robberies.

Bandit leader

Level 2, HP 8, Toughness 2, WT 4 (chain)

Traits: Stealthy.

Typical gear: 1-h sword (2 dmg), dagger (2 dmg, can be thrown), chain armor, d20 (11) sp

Usual wants: Money. Wine. Valuable gear. Easy robberies. To succeed the boss.

||

OVERLAND TRAVEL

The mechanics in this chapter are not meant to be played as a mini-game of it's own. Rather, they are designed as an overarching structure that interact with the players' resources (time, food, water, fatigue etc.) during travels, and when combined with the players' goals, give raise to opportunities for interesting interactions and meaningful choice.

Travel points

The company gets 8 travel points (TP) each day.

- ▶ Subtract 2 TP if at least one member of the company is encumbered or injured. Subtract 4 TP if at least one member of the company is both encumbered and injured. A character that is traveling on a mount does not incur a TP penalty.
- ▶ Subtract 2 points when traveling in bad weather.

To enter a hex, the company must pay its travel point cost. If there is not enough points to enter the next hex on the route, take note of the unspent travel points, and subtract it from the hex cost of the next hex entered.

Food and water

Each character must consume one ration each day or gain an instance of fatigue. It is assumed that the company is able to acquire the needed water each day, except when traveling in deserts. When entering a desert hex for the first time each day, each character must drink water equal to one full waterskin, or gain 2 instances of fatigue.

Hunting

Spend 1 day hunting and roll a successful DC2 survival check to locate game. Roll random encounter as if traveling (2-in-6 chance). Roll 1d6 to determine game type:

- ▶ 1-2: Deer. WT 4. 12 rations.
- ▶ 3-4: Rabbit. WT 1. 2 ration.
- ▶ 5-6: Turkey. WT 1. 3 rations.

When you spot the animal, you are still at a good distance apart from it. Shooting at this distance is a DC3 shot. Sneaking closer will reduce the difficulty of the shot (choose one):

- ▶ DC1 stealth check reduces the DC to 2.
- ▶ DC2 stealth check reduces the DC to 1.
- ▶ DC3 stealth check reduces the DC to 0.

If you hit the animal and inflict damage at the WT or higher, you mortally injure the animal, and quickly find it dead or dying. Doing less than WT damage injures the animal, but not fatally. To get a second

attempt to kill it requires tracking it for 1 watch and passing a DC1 survival check. The DC for the shot is the same as above. It's not possible to track an animal during nighttime.

Time

There are 10 seconds in a round, 6 rounds in a minute, 10 minutes in a turn, 6 turns in an hour, 24 hours in a day.

Mules and horses

If the company has the means and are able to procure them, they can bring horses along on their journeys.

Horses

- ▶ Horses can only travel through terrain costing 2 or 3 travel points.
- ▶ A horse costs 300 sp and can carry gear equal to 20 inventory slots with a rider (usually taking over the rider's inventory), or 40 inventory slots without a rider.
- ▶ A horse needs 1 slot worth of fodder each day to avoid gaining an instance of fatigue.
- ▶ When entering a desert hex for the first time each day, a horse must drink water equal to one full waterskin, or gain 2 instances of fatigue.

BOX: TRAVEL DAY PROCEDURE

1. **Weather.** The GM rolls and describes the weather to the players.
2. **Calculate travel points.** 8 TP is the default. -2 TP if encumbered or injured. -4 TP if encumbered and injured. Mounted characters does not incur penalty to TP. -2 TP for bad weather.
3. **Decide on route for the day.**
4. **Resolve the day.**
 1. **Random encounter.** 2-in-6 chance each day spent traveling. If an encounter is rolled, roll which hex the encounter is happening in.
 2. **Overt features** connected to a hex that is entered are described to the players, and interactions are resolved.
5. **End of day.** The GM removes one token of the watch stack.

TERRAIN

Terrain are classified as either regular, difficult or impassable (see Terrain table below). When

calculating the cost to enter a hex, count 1 hex of difficult terrain as 2 hexes of regular terrain.

SHELTER AND SLEEP

To get a good night's sleep outdoors you need a bedroll. During bad weather or winter you also need shelter. If you fail to get a good night's sleep, you gain an instance of fatigue.

ENCOUNTERS

To determine who notices who first, roll 1d6: On a:

- 1-2: The other party notices the PCs first.
- 3-4: Both parties notice each other.
- 5-6: The PCs notice the other party first.

Terrain		
Cost	Terrain	Survival DC for locating game
2	Roads through any terrain	-
2	Plains	2
2	Open Forest	2
2	River or lake (requires boat/raft)	-
2	Hills	2
3	Marsh/swamp/bog/fen	3
3	Desert	4
4	Thick Forest	3
4	Jungle	3
4	Mountains	3
4	High Mountain Pass (b)	-
Impassable	High Mountains	-

1 Disaster Strikes	
d20	Details
1	Ascent/decent
2	Trip or fall
3	Dangerous/slippery path
4	Rock-/mudslide/avalanche
5	Trap
6	Loose rocks
7	Slippery ground
8	Falling branch
9	River crossing
10	Wildlife attack
11	Hunter becomes hunted
12	
13	Hunting accident
14	Stampede
15	Accident during fog
16	Storm
17	Cut
18	Snakebite
19	Poisonous plant/mushroom
20	Fire/heat

2 Hopelessness and frustration	
d20	Details
1	Map shows glaring errors
2	Blocked trail/path
3	Impenetrable thicket
4	Dead end
5	Thorns, torn clothes or gear
6	Spooked game
7	Unattended camp
8	Unseen obstacle
9	Food going bad
10	Soaked clothes and equipment
11	Cold or heat
12	
13	Difficulties lighting fire
14	Unsuitable camping ground
15	Thunderstorm
16	Cursed hunt/bad luck
17	Foul tasting catch
18	Insects
19	Deceptive mirage
20	Lost supplies

3 Fear	
d20	Details
1	Fire
2	Quicksand
3	Signs of dangerous predator
4	Feral animal(s)
5	Fog/maze-like terrain
6	Bridge/path collapses
7	Otherworldly presence
8	Sounds during the night
9	Dangerous wildlife
10	Almost poisoned
11	Dark history at location
12	Animals serving the enemy
13	Burial grounds
14	Dead travelers
15	Deranged hunter/traveler
16	Grisly scene or portent
17	Malevolent being
18	Scary terrain
19	Someone almost killed
20	Frightening silhouette

4 Wavering Faith	
d20	Details
1	Ruminating on choices
2	Hard to stay awake on watch
3	Game spooked
4	Injured pray
5	Rookie mistake
6	Inadequate shelter
7	Misjudging terrain difficulty
8	Confusing environment
9	Misread weather signs
10	Loosing tracks or path
11	Lost
12	Faulty map reading
13	Misguided shortcut
14	Misjudging distance
15	Damages/looses equipment
16	Disastrous cooking
17	Unsure about edibility
18	Failure preserving rations
19	Animals gets to rations
20	Too much salt

5 Renewed Faith	
d20	Details
1	Hidden or forgotten trail or road
2	Hidden pass or ford
3	Old signpost
4	Gamble pays off
5	Easy terrain
6	Not lost anymore
7	Tip from local hunter
8	Spotting dead end early
9	High ground revelation
10	Well functioning camp
11	Tough hunt well executed
12	Animal trail
13	Plentiful game
14	Well planned supplies
15	Gear holding up
16	Nature's bounties
17	Finding the way out
18	Sighting aids navigation
19	Useful flora
20	Cuts or small wounds treated

6 Gratitude	
d20	Details
1	Moving song
2	Friendly locals
3	Sharing campfire stories
4	Abandoned resources
5	Blessed pool
6	Hot springs
7	Beautiful morning
8	Meteor shower
9	Hidden oasis/glade
10	Natural shelter
11	Favorable weather
12	Breathtaking view
13	Hearty breakfast
14	Excellent dinner
15	Safe campsite
16	Sturdy camp during storm
17	Rear animal/bird sighting
18	Awaited landmark
19	Lost shrine or monument
20	High quality catch

SITE EXPLORATION

A company of adventurers will often find themselves exploring dangerous areas, like haunted ruins, hostile fortifications or ancient tombs inhabited by the restless dead. Such areas are collectively called adventures sites.

TIME

The GM indicates to the players the current time of day (morning, afternoon, evening, night) to anchor rhythms at the adventure site, e.g. light and darkness, denizens sleeping, hunters leaving to hunt or meal times. The passage of time is not tracked in more detail than this.

ENCOUNTERS

Every time the company performs a significant action, makes noise or otherwise potentially draws unwanted attention to themselves, the GM rolls an encounter die. The size of the encounter die is set by the GM (the default is a d12). On a 1 the GM either rolls or picks an encounter from the area's encounter table.

What counts as a significant action must be adjudicated by the GM. Examples of significant actions are searching a room for hidden doors, moving through an earlier explored area, skimming a manuscript, clearing moss off an old fresco, or anything that would take a couple of minutes to perform.

The GM rolls the encounter die in the open so the players can see the size of the die (and the frequency of encounters) and the result.

LIGHT

Common sources of light available to adventurers are:

- ▶ **Torches.** A torch can be used as an improvised weapon (2 damage). A torch that is dropped has a 3-in-6 chance of being extinguished. Torches filling one slot in inventory cannot be split up to provide several individual simultaneous sources of light.
- ▶ **Lanterns.** Lamps can be covered without extinguishing its flame. A lit lantern must be held in one hand to effectively provide light. A lantern that is dropped has a 3-in-6 chance of being extinguished and break.

Remaining torches and lantern fuel is not tracked. If a character has either torches or a lantern in their inventory, they have a source of light.

When a band of adventurers operate in a dark environment, they need one light source for every action that is carried out simultaneously. Anything up close (1 meter) can be seen clearly. Anything 10 meters away are bare outlines.

Fire is usually created with a tinderbox. Creating a flame with a tinderbox takes 10 game-world minutes. Creating fire without a tinderbox requires a successful survival check with 3 hits, taking 1 game-world hour.

Lamp oil are hard to ignite and cannot be used as a molotov cocktail. Greek fire, pitch or tar would be better alternatives for incendiaries.

SNEAKING AND HIDING

When a company explores a dangerous site, it is assumed that they are doing what they can to move undetected at all times.

Carrying a light source in an otherwise dark environment usually precludes going undetected.

Any stealth checks are rolled by the member of the group with the lowest stealth skill.

Hiding is done by interacting with the game world: Finding a suitable spot to hide, and getting there undetected.

Surprise and ambushes

To ambush a group of opponents, the ambushers must first notice their opponents. The GM then sets a difficulty depending on the situation and the ambusher with the lowest stealth rolls a stealth check.

DOORS

When encountering a **locked door**, the lock is given an opposition between 0 to 4 by the GM. When a character has access to lockpicks and unlimited time, they can successfully pick any lock up to an opposition 2 above their skill level.

When in a risky situation (e.g. trying to unlock a door before being noticed by hostiles), a successful thievery check at the matching difficulty is required to avoid the risk.

Locked doors can usually be **broken through** as long as the characters have suitable gear for the job (crowbars, axes etc.). Braking down a door causes a lot of noise and will usually trigger an escalation.

SEARCHING

When a character searches the right spot, they find what is there.

EQUIPMENT AND ECONOMICS

COINS AND MONEY

1 gold piece (gp) = 100 silver pieces (sp) = 10 000 copper pieces (cp).

1 silver piece is the average daily wage of unskilled labor, and will pay for one person's room and board of adequate quality for 1 day. All prices are given in sp if not otherwise specified.

BUYING AND SELLING ITEMS

Players can expect to buy an item at the amount listed in this chapter, and sell an item for 50% of its value, given access to a suitable market for the item. Settlement size decides the availability of items of different value categories. See the Item Availability table on the next page for the amount (or probability) of finding a buyer, or a seller, for an item in a certain value range. Availability is "refreshed" every week.

PACK ANIMALS

Mules

- ▶ 50 inventory slots.
- ▶ Incurs -1d to travel checks.
- ▶ Can travel in all terrain except deserts.
- ▶ Costs 150 sp.

SURVIVAL GEAR

During challenges in the wilderness, each relevant piece of equipment for the challenge gives +1d.

Example: The company faces a blizzard in the wilderness, and each character must pass a DC2 survival check or gain 1 fatigue. A character with furs, bedroll and a tent receives +3d on the check.

Standards of Living			
Standard of Living	Daily Cost	Monthly Cost	Professions
Wretched	2 cp	6 sp	Beggar
Adequate	1 sp	30 sp	Unskilled laborer
Comfortable	2 sp	60 sp	Skilled artisan
Wealthy	5 sp	150 sp	Mayor
Luxurious	30 sp	900 sp	Noble

Item Availability by Settlement Size

Item price/ settlement size	Hamlet (<50)	Village (50-1k)	Small town (1k-4k)	Large town (4k-8k)	City (>8k)
≤1	10	200	800	1600	4000
2-10	3	60	240	480	1200
11-100	25%	5	20	40	100
101-1 000	10%	2	8	16	40
1001-10 000	5%	1	4	8	20
>10 000	1%	20%	1	2	4

Light sources

Item	Notes	Price
Candle (6)	Bundled. Provides dim light for 1 character for 1 hour.	1
Lantern	Provides bright light for 2 adventurers, and dim light for 2 more. Requires a refill every 6 turns. Lamps can be covered without extinguishing its flame.	10
Oil flask	Contains 3 re-fills for a lantern	2
Torch (3)	Bundled. One torch lasts 6 turns and provides bright light for 2 adventurers, and dim light for 2 more.	1

Survival Gear

Item	Details	Price
Bedroll		5
Cooking pots		3
Fishing rod and tackle		3
Furs	For cold weather	10
Rations (1 day)		1
Tent	Space for 3 people	15
Tinderbox	Takes 10 min to light	2
Waterskin	Holds enough water for 1 person for 1 day	5

Food and Drinks

Description	Price
Mug of ale	0.5 cp
Basic food and drink for 1 day	5 cp
Fine food and drink for 1 day	1 sp
Exquisite food and drink for 1 day	5 sp

Lodging

Description	Price (1 night)*
Common room	.5 sp
Private room	2 sp
Guesthouse	5 sp
Lodge	15 sp
Noble estate	50 sp

*Includes food and lodging

Homes & Estates

Description	Price
Small cottage	5 gp
Townhouse	20 gp
Farm w/50 acres	50 gp
Estate w/500 acres	500 gp
Castle or Stronghold	1000+ gp

Adventuring Gear		
Item	Details	Price
Book (Blank)		10
Chisel		5
Crowbar		5
Chalk	Tiny.	1
Bandages (3 uses)	Bundled in 1 slot. Gain +1d when giving first aid.	1
Grappling Hook		5
Hammer		10
Map of Local Area		10
Marbles (bag of 50)	Bundled in 1 slot.	2
Pickaxe		10
Quill and Ink		2
Rope	50 feet.	5
Pitons (10)	Bundled in 1 slot.	5
Quiver of arrows/bolts	Includes 20 arrows/bolts	10
Shovel		5
Spyglass		50
Lock picks		10
Whetstone		2
Fire arrows		5

MAGIC

Paradigm

How does the practitioner perform magic? Demonic pacts? Voodoo? Calling upon heathen gods? Spilling their own blood?

The sorcerer chooses their spell and the Opposition. Attempting the spell has a base cost of fatigue points equal to the Opposition.

- Critical: Effect achieved, half fatigue cost (rounded down)
- Success: Effect achieved
- Failure: Effect achieved, double fatigue cost
- Fumble: Half effect achieved (if possible), double fatigue cost.

The effect has a good chance of happening by coincidence? ADV.

The effects is obviously caused by magic? DIS.

Custom spell

Describe effect. GM sets DC between 1 and 5. This is also the fatigue cost. Success = happens. Critical = half cost. Failure = Happens but at double cost. Fumble = no effect, normal cost.

Mend

- Requires touching the person.
- Heals 2 HP x DC.
- DC 1/2/3 to prevent a gravely wounded person who rolled a 4/3/2 from dying.

Rend

- Must be able to see the victim.
- Inflict 2 damage x DC. Does not inflict wound.
- Kill a person = DC 5.

RUNNING THE GAME

RUNNING MONSTERS

1. Gate defeat by non standard means behind 3 steps.
2. Each step defaults to an opposed check.
 1. Failing a check on one of the steps should not erase the players' previous progress. Let it cost dearly in some other way (items lost, HP, injuries etc.).
 2. One step could be broken down into two steps to make the risk more acceptable for the players.

Example: Klatre pillar → Hoppe på ryggen dens → klatre opp halsen → stikke den gjennom hodet.

REWARD CREATIVITY

DOWNPLAY BALANCE

Challenge is important to a good game. Some games handle challenge by trying to carefully balance the strength of the opposition to the strength of the PCs. This necessitates restricting players' creative ideas that would upset this balance.

I suggest instead that GMs create situations where the party is clearly outmatched in a straight up fight, requiring the players to investigate the game world, and plan, scheme and use every available resource to gain the upper hand.

If the players come up with a good plan that turns a challenging situation into a cakewalk, roll with it. It is common for GMs to believe that players' will find the game unrewarding if they sometimes find an "easy" solution to a significant conflict, but in reality, most players find it rewarding and empowering to be able to "beat the system" from time to time. Do not listen to your brain telling you that they need to have a really tough time at every significant challenge to enjoy the moment and the game. It is simply not true.

Encounter difficulty

- ▶ Focusing on one PC increases the difficulty of a combat encounter. Spreading out the attacks among several PCs lowers it.

CHECKS

When deciding outcomes for an action that requires a check, there are three general categories of outcome combinations. The check can be about:

- ▶ Whether the goal is achieved or not. In

addition, the attempt either has:

- ▶ A cost on a failed check.
- ▶ A cost regardless of outcome.
- ▶ Whether a cost is avoided or not. The goal is achieved regardless.

If you can't come up with a plausible negative consequence in the case of a failed *check*, default to automatic success without a die roll.

Keep a printout (see appendix, TODO) of the skills within reach during play, so you can easily find the most relevant skill for an intended action.

RULINGS

NPCs

Non-player-characters (NPCs) do not have separate skills like player characters do. Instead they have:

- ▶ **A level** between 0 and 5. The level is the general skill level of the NPC. Vanlige folk er 0. Vakter er 1. Veteraner er 2. Eliter er 3. 4 og 5 er forbeholdt helt eksepsjonelle skapninger.
- ▶ **Descriptors.** Give the creature +1d or -1d to any rolls covered by actions where the

NPC Strength		
Quality	HP	Wound Threshold
Very weak	1	1 (unarmed hit)
Weak	5	2 (1h weapon)
Medium	10	3 (2h weapon)
Strong	15	4 (critical hit 1h/2h)
Very strong	25	5 (critical hit from 2h)

descriptor would be an advantage or disadvantage.

ENCOUNTERS

Pre-roll everything that can be pre-rolled (e.g. type and number of creatures for an encounter, current behavior or goals, initial reaction, whether they are encountered in a lair or not, any treasure that can be found).

Chance meetings

Include possibly helpful entities in your encounter table. See the Chance meetings table for inspiration.

Rolling for encounters

The old school way of rolling encounters is a 1-in-6 chance every 2 turns. I suggest grabbing a handful of d6s and rolling them all together, and then going from left to right position on the table. Any 1s is an encounter.

When getting close to the next encounter, consider showing signs of what is coming.

Roll to determine the exact encounter

Build a d6 encounter table for your area. Restricting it to 6 encounters makes it easier to come up with interesting encounters with meaningful behavior tied to the area.

One encounter should be very dangerous.

Several encounters can involve the same being(s), varying its situation and behavior.

RUNNING COMBAT

Combatants always have goals

Combats are the extension of actors pursuing their goals. Neither goblins nor dragons automatically attack other beings on sight. In deciding to attack, the creature's goal and alternative ways of obtaining it should be weighted against the creature's perception of the risk of combat.

A pack of goblins attack a lightly defended merchant caravan with the goal of looting it, expecting an easy fight. When a group of seasoned adventurers emerge from one of the carriages and starts cutting into the goblins' ranks, they quickly turn tail and retreat.

A dragon grabs an adventurer as a morning snack, perceiving little risk from the small band of humanoids.

NPC Morale

Check when first ally falls. check again when half of allies have fallen. When 2/3 of allies have fallen, all but fanatics flee.

Will to live

Almost no creatures fight to the death if they can avoid it. Most creatures, be it man or beast, fight as long as they think they have a reasonable chance of getting what they want, but turn and flee when the odds tip against them.

Alternatives to killing PCs

It is seldom the most interesting solution to kill a PC if he or she is at the mercy of a hostile NPC. Consider alternate developments like:

Captured by the enemy

Put into long-lasting coma

Crippled

Enslaved, either locally or shipped off to a far away location

Hostage for ransom

Changed in some way

Looses his/her memory

Joins the enemy

Otherworldly intervention with a plan not obviously preferable to death

Possessed

Exiled

Cursed

Bound by magic to a sinister plan or will

Declared lawless

COMPLICATIONS FOR FUMBLING

Some suggestions for potential trouble:

Gear breaks

Falls prone

Loses weapon

Weapon stuck

PC gets stuck

PCs gets separated

PC gets out of position

Gear slips loose

Mechanism jams

Hinders ally

Something dangerous approaches - show signs

Damage

Situation changes

Enemy reinforcements

The most exciting checks are checks that have about a 50/50 chance of success, and are really important, with high risk and reward. For example, we want to avoid a check where the player has a 5% chance of killing the dragon with an arrow, where failing would mean she misses the shot. A better check would be a 50% chance of killing the dragon, but a miss would result in getting incinerated.

PROGRESSIVE CHECKS

My take:

- Set a number of checks required (not successful checks, but checks in general). If you want to, sketch out a progress clock (like the ones used in *Blades in the Dark* RPG) for the players.
- Heighten the tension with every failed check:
 1. No direct consequence, but a slightly worse position
 2. No direct consequence, but a clearly worse position
 3. Consequences

EVALUATING PLANS

Some pointers might be of help for a GM evaluating players' plans. First:

Is the action possible, and can it lead to the goal? If not, explain why to the player. The issue probably stems from a discrepancy in how the player and GM sees the situation in the theaters of their minds.

If the plan is sound, decide between resolving with or without dice:

Is it risky? If not, resolve without dice. Sometimes you might want to take into consideration the character's level in the relevant skill. An action might be risky for someone untrained, but might be routine for a veteran in the field.

If a *check* is warranted:

Decide on a fail state, preferably a "fail forward", like attaining the goal, but with an added complication, or cost, that a success would have avoided (e.g. "Should you fail the *check*, you scale the palisade, but doing so exposes your outline longer than you had hoped. Someone will notice you moving over the wall").

Consider modifiers. Are any significant factors influencing the chance of success? If so, apply +1d for advantages, and -1d for disadvantages.

On describing failures: If a skilled character fails a *check*, describe the result as caused by external factors and bad luck. This helps prevent a slapstick spiral. If, on the other hand, the character is untrained at what they attempted, a description emphasizing lack of skill might be more appropriate.

ON AGENCY AND INFORMATION

When faced with an important choice, the player should have information about the fail state, the success state and the odds, before having to choose between going through with a plan or not. This

information helps "calibrate" the fictional situation between player and GM, making the world predictable to a degree where meaningful choices can be made.

When this information is absent, it can undermine autonomy and lead to less than satisfying experiences, like the example below.

Player wants to set fire to the evil tree.

Player: "I throw my oil lantern at the tree!"

GM: "Roll Athletics to throw it."

Player: Rolls Athletics, but fails. Thinks about it, then spends the resource Divine Favor, turning the check into a success.

GM: "You hit it. It takes 4 damage. It does not catch fire".

Player: "Wait, what? I thought I rolled to see if I would set it on fire or not?"

GM: "No, you rolled to see if you hit or not, but the tree is wet, and you would need more heat to ignite it".

Player: ".....".

CONVERSION FROM D20 FANTASY

3 HP x Hit Dice. Use half of level if the monster seems especially bad at something.

The GM uses the NPCs' **goals, problems** and **demeanor** to come up with reasonable responses to the PCs' proposals. If it is unclear how an NPC would react, the GM sets a difficulty between minor (1 hit) and epic (3 hits), and the player rolls a check with the skill best covering the chosen approach. Three social skills are included as standard: Deception, enhearten and reason.

Each NPC has a demeanor. Human-intelligence creatures can have one of the demeanors of:

- Altruistic. Will help even at significant cost to themselves.
- Friendly. Will help if the cost to themselves is not significant.
- Neutral. Will usually only agree to a proposal if they gain something of equal worth to what they give up.
- Exploitative. Not hindered by causing minor harm to innocent others while pursuing their goals.
- Sociopathic. No qualms in causing serious harm to others while pursuing their goals.
- Sadistic. Enjoys causing harm to other beings, and may go out of their way to do so.

To introduce some randomness to which demeanor a specific NPC holds, the class demeanor of the NPC can be modified with a roll on the table below. A positive modifier shifts the NPC's demeanor the given number of steps towards the prosocial end of the scale, while a negative modifier shifts it towards the antisocial.

DEFEATING POWERFUL MONSTERS

Some monsters are so strong that facing them in a straight up fight would spell doom for your company. If you want to have any hope defeating such creatures you need to formulate a plan where you utilize some form of advantage, resource or vulnerability of the creature.

Propose your plan to your GM. If the GM believes the plan can work, she will usually discuss with you how the plan can be broken down into smaller, concrete steps/actions that need to be completed before the final blow can be attempted.

The best plans are those where the initial step(s) can be completed relatively risk-free by utilizing knowledge, gear or strategy, reserving high risk checks for later steps in the plan.

Reward size	Payment in sp	Equals payment for unskilled labor for...
Small	7	1 week
Medium	14	2 weeks
Large	30	1 month
Very large	180	6 months

Demeanor Modification	
2d6	Demeanor Modifier
2	-3
3	-2
4	-1
5-9	-
10	+1
11	+2
12	+3

Encounter A

9 orcs from the Grimclaw clan hunting for game. Also always interested in new slaves to work their silver mines.

Encounter B

Company size + 2 bandits guarding bridge, demanding 50 silver per head to pass. The bandits have foreign accents, and are part of a larger raider force from a newly established bandit stronghold on a nearby island.

Custom event

Long stretches of dense forest and thicket. Thorns, pulling at clothes. One member of the party rolls a Survival *check*. On success, spots 3 portions of Athelas leaf.

Company: Agility *check* to avoid losing a random small item (roll d20 on inventory until small item comes up).

disposition modifier rolled.

Example: A player character is attempting to sneak into a city within the territory of a hostile tribe. The GM uses the encounter table for the area, and rolls "2 guards". The player rolls stealth against the guards and wins the check, so he will notice them before they notice him. The guards has a general disposition of Suspicious. The GM rolls 2d6 for a result of 4, translating into a modifier of -1, taking the guard's disposition from Suspicious to Irritable.

Possible factors.

The preceding roleplay or social strategy (bribes, threats, charm etc.) described by the player.

The attitude of the other party.

The adventures' reputation.

The procedure in this chapter handles encounters with men and beasts in the wilderness and adventure sites. Encounter tables should include both creature and non-creature encounters, like places, monuments, natural phenomena or any other interesting, intractable aspect of the game world. Arnold Kemp over at the Goblin Punch blog suggests a d6 encounter table with the following entries:

1. A normal animal
2. A special animal
3. A dangerous encounter
4. A deadly encounter
5. An NPC linked to the world/adventure
6. A dangerous NPC

Creature encounters

Encounters with creatures can contain clear suggestions pertaining to who notices who first and the other side's reaction to the PCs. If so, the GM may skip steps below as she sees fit.

1. **What is encountered:** Roll on the encounter table for the area the party is currently in. If a non-creature encounter is rolled, exit the procedure and go directly into describing the scene.
2. **Awareness:** Roll an opposed stealth check for the two sides (lowest stealth members rolls). The winner notices the other side.
3. **Reaction:** To determine the initial reaction of the creature(s), either choose the creature's disposition to the party, or roll 2d6 on the Reaction table and modify the creature's base disposition by x number of steps on the table, where x is the

NPC Dispositions

Disposition	Description
1 - Actively Malicious	This individual not only finds it acceptable to cause harm and misfortune to others, but takes pleasure in it. They pursue their goals with no regard for the wellbeing of others. When an opportunity to cause misery arises, it is seen as a bonus. This creature shows hostility beyond mere defense of territory or predatory instinct, and may kill for the joy of it.
2 - Hostile	This individual sees the party as a threat, obstacle, competition or opportunity, and has little qualms with manipulating, cheating or inflicting harm to the party's members as long as they perceive a clear benefit. This animal often sees other creatures as prey or attack unprovoked, sometimes even outside of it's own territory.
3 - Irritable	This individual is easily annoyed, responding with impatience or hostility if provoked. They may not be actively malicious but have a low tolerance for inconvenience or disrespect. This creature has an aggressive nature, lashing out when disturbed. It may be territorial or naturally inclined to view others as threats or pray.
4 - Suspicious	This individual is cautious and skeptical of the party, taking a guarded approach in any interactions. They may be open to cooperation, but trust must be earned. This animal is skittish or defensive, keeping its distance and avoiding close interaction. If threatened or cornered, it may respond with a warning display or defensive behavior.
5 - Neutral	This individual is neither particularly friendly nor hostile. They may be open to conversation or negotiation but generally only interested in doing any deals where they see a clear net upside for themselves. This animal is focused on their own needs. It largely ignores passersby unless they come too close or interfere with its immediate environment.
6 - Friendly	This individual is approachable and eager to engage with others in a positive manner. They may help the party as long as it does not incur a significant net cost to themselves. This animal is curious and non-threatening, showing an interest in interacting peacefully. It may approach to investigate but will not attack or show aggression unless provoked.
7 - Actively Helpful	This individual goes out of its way to assist the party, possibly offering resources, guidance, or aid, even if it incurs a significant net cost to themselves. This animal is instinctively friendly, either by training or by nature.

Disposition Modifiers

2d6	Disposition	Disposition Modifier	Probability
2	Actively Malicious	-3	.03
3	Hostile	-2	.06
4-5	Irritable	-1	.19
6-8	Suspicious	-	.44
9-10	Neutral	+1	.19
11	Friendly	+2	.06
12	Actively Helpful	+3	.03

BESTIARY

Goblin

HP 3: □□□

Wounds : □

DC 1 **Armor** 3d (leather) **Size:** S

Damage: 2 (1-h spear/bow/dagger)

Skill adjustments: Stealth 2, grace 2

Attacks

- 1-3 Weapon damage (2)
Critical strike. Weapon damage + 1
4-5 (3). Pass armor check to avoid wound.
6 Weapon damage (2) + Trip.

Notes

When attacked: 3-in-6 chance of grabbing a fellow engaged goblin, pulling the victim into the line of fire, causing the victim to be the target of the attack.

Usual wants: Shiny things. Tasty food. To run away.

Troll

HP 15:

Wounds

DC 3 **Armor** 3d (natural)

Typical gear: Great club (3 dmg, 1h)

DIS: Stealth, grace

Gambits

Sweeping blow. All adjacent creatures must pass a grace check or take weapon damage.

Stomp. All engaged creatures must pass a grace check or fall prone.

Knock back. Inflicts weapon damage and sends the target flying through the air, landing prone nearby and dropping any worn helmet one move away.

Grab. Grabs an opponent with one hand (victim grappled). Follows up next turn with **Bite** where victim must roll melee, brawn or grace to oppose. Failure inflicts 3 dmg and a wound. If target is already wounded, he or she is decapitated. Successfully opposing breaks the grapple.

Notes

Usual wants: Meat (prefers mutton and human), gold.

Giant

HP 12: □□□□□ □□□□□ □□

Wounds : □□□

DC 3 **Armor** 3d (natural)

Damage: 3 (tree trunk, 1h), 2 (unarmed)

Skill adjustments: Stealth 1, grace 1

Attacks

1-2: **Club.**

3: **Stomp.** All engaged creatures must succeed on an opposed grace check or fall prone.

4: **Knock back.** Sends an opponent flying through the air. The opponent lands prone nearby and drops any worn helmet.

5-6: **Grab.** Grabs an opponent with one hand (victim grappled). Follows up next turn with **Bite** (signal the seriousness of this to the players). The victim must roll melee, brawn or grace to oppose. Failure means the victim is decapitated. Succeeding breaks the grapple.

Notes

Usual wants: Meat (prefers mutton and human), livestock, playthings.

Black Wyrn		
HP 15	Wounds 3	Ferocity 2
DC 3		Dmg 3 (natural)
Armor 6d (natural)		
Actions		
Breath: All nearby combatants must succeed on a grace check or suffer 3 damage from it's scorching breath.		
Tail slam. One target rolls melee or grace to avoid. On a fail the wyrn sends the target flying through the air landing nearby. Victim takes 1 damage and lands prone. Any worn helmet lands far away. Critical:		
Claws. 3 damage. Critical: Base + roll armor to avoid wound.		
Bite. Victim takes 3 damage. Critical: Base + succeed on a grit check or paralyzed for the rest of the fight from the wyrn's poison.		
Notes		
Black, glistening, steel-like scales. Only loose HP taking 4 or more damage in one blow.		
Usual wants: To eat, to sleep and to protect and grow it's hoard.		

Veteran Infantry		
HP 7	Wounds 2	Ferocity 1
DC 2 (ADV on defense from shield)		
Armor 4d (leather 3d, helmet 1d)		
Damage: 2 (gear)		
Typical gear: Sword, shield, helmet, dagger, leather armor		
Criticals		
Shield Bash. Target takes 1 damage, tumbles backward and falls prone.		
Blind. Target takes weapon damage and starts to bleed profusely from forehead. Obscures vision until given successful first aid (standard apothecary feat) as an action.		
Notes		
When not in melee: 3-in-6 chance of throwing it's spear.		
Usual wants: War spoils. Winnable fights. To be paid.		

Bandit leader	
DC: 2	
HP: 10	
Wounds: 1	
Armor: 3d (from gear)	
Typical gear: 1-h sword (2 dmg), dagger (2 dmg, can be thrown), leather armor	
Attacks (d6)	
1	Elbow/knee and trip. 1 damage + trip
2	Grab weapon. Grabs and pins opponent's weapon with rag-wrapped hand. Opponent must pass a brawn, grace or melee check to unpin the weapon.
3	Cut. Weapon damage.
Critical attacks (d3)	
4	Critical strike. Weapon damage + 1. Opponent must pass an armor check or sustain a wound
5	Cut and disarm. Weapon damage + opponent's weapon lands nearby
6	Pocket sand. Throws sand in opponent's eyes. Causes DIS for two whole turns. Can be cleared as an action.
Notes	
Usual wants: Money. Wine. Valuable gear. Easy robberies.	

Ogre

Level: 3 HP: 25, Armor: 1 (gambeson)
Size: Large

Attacks:

Tree trunk (3d, 6 dmg). Very long reach. Can only be parried by shield (-1d).

Stomp (3d, 6 dmg).

Grab (4d). Struggle with Brawn -2d to escape.

Squash grabbed creature 5 dmg. Always hits.

When outnumbered: Prefers to wait for opponents to try to close range, then lands attack with knockback.
Skills: Brawn (4d).

Usual wants: Dominate other creatures in battle, meat.

Dragon

Level: 6 HP: 40, Armor: 5 (scales) Size: Huge

Attacks:

Breathe fire (6d, 6 dmg). Cannot be parried. Cone 30 m long and 10 m wide at end.

Bite (6d, 8 dmg).

Claw (6d, 6 dmg). Shreds armor on hit.

Tail (6d, 5 damage). 10 m reach. Knockback.

Wings (6d). All characters within 10 m must succeed on an opposed Athletics *check* or fall prone.

Once per round, the dragon can perform an Action at the end of another creature's turn.

Skills:

Usual wants: Treasure, being feared, domination over a large area.

Gorka

Level 2 Size 0
Hit Points 9 (2d8) Speed 30', swim 30
Damage 2 Armor 1 (natural)
Vulnerabilities (1d)

Attacks

Trident. Melee attack: reach 2, size 2. Win: 2 damage. Critical Win: Impale.

Dagger. Melee attack: reach 5, size 1. Win: 2 damage. Critical Win: Bleed.

Other Actions

Submerge. When in a swamp, a gorka can submerge itself in water or mud, and stay submerged for 30 minutes.

Notes

Appearance: Humanoid, brown skin, potbellied, long limbs, wide set eyes.

Demeanor: Friendly. Staccato speech.

Usual wants: Fish, protect its village.

Gorkas live in swamps where they build villages consisting of small reed-and-mud houses elevated on stilts. They grow wild rice, use nets and tridents to catch fish and supplement their diet with foraged swamp berries, roots and waterfowl eggs.